

Incident Handler's journal : ransomware incident analysis

1. Description

Analyzed a ransomware incident affecting a healthcare organization and documented findings using an Incident Handler's Journal. Applied the 5 w's framework (who, what, where, when, why) to identify the threat actor, attack method, business impact, and likely motivation behind the attack.

2. Key activities

- reviewed a phishing-based ransomware scenario
- Identified initial access through a malicious email attachment
- Documented the attack timeline and operational impact
- Analyzed threat actor objectives and financial motivations
- Practiced incident documentation techniques used in security operations

3. Skill demonstrated

- Incident response
- Security incident documentation
- Threat analysis
- Phishing attack analysis
- Ransomware investigation
- Critical thinking
- Cybersecurity reporting

4. Key Finding

- human error remains one of the most common entry points for cyberattacks
- phishing emails can bypass technical controls when employees are not adequately trained
- Ransomware can quickly disrupt critical services, especially in healthcare environments where system availability is essential
- Incident documentation provides a structured way to understand an attack and support response efforts.

5. Lesson learned

- security awareness training is one of the most effective defenses against phishing attacks
- Organizations should maintain offline backups and tested recovery procedures to reduce the impact of ransomware
- Early detection and rapid incident response can significantly limit operational disruption
- Proper documentation is a critical component of incident response because it helps teams investigate, contain, and learn from security incidents.